

EXECUTIVE BRIEF

Trust the Health Indicator Only After Testing Its Denominator

What leaders should authorize, require, and refuse

Production Unit	PU-B07-C26
Decision status	Controlled learning asset
Audience	Executives, programme owners, statisticians, technical leads
Data	Synthetic examples only

Executive takeaway: Trust a health indicator only after testing its numerator, denominator, target population, reference period, coverage, and revision status.

Why it matters

A plausible rate can mislead when its denominator excludes, duplicates, or misclassifies the population at risk.

Illustrative application

A maternal-care rate uses eligible pregnancies rather than all women as its denominator.

Minimum approval conditions

- Named accountable owner and lawful purpose
- Defined evidence, provenance, reference period, population, and geography
- Decision-relevant validation and visible uncertainty
- Documented abstention, referral, override, and incident processes
- Accessibility, equity, security, retention, and retirement review

Non-negotiable boundary

The analytical system may inform review. It may not independently authorize benefits, sanctions, enforcement, clinical treatment, school exclusion, displacement, or another consequential action.